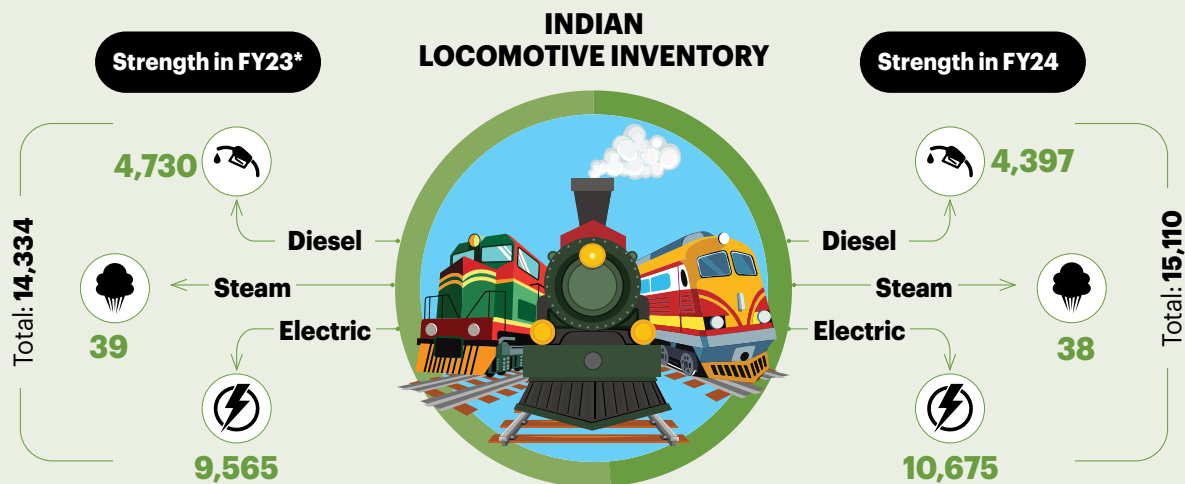


ELECTRIC STORY

• Indian Railways is looking to ramp up production of electric locomotives



NOTE AS ON MARCH 31, 2024 **SOURCE** INDIAN RAILWAYS ANNUAL REPORT 2023-24

52 |

electrification. The changes in rules for captive freight movement inside sidings have made things worse.

Lalit Chandra Trivedi, former general manager, East Central Railway, explains that earlier, the system allowed for private sidings, especially those belonging to industrial sectors such as coal, cement, steel, and aluminium, to deploy their own dedicated locomotives for internal shunting and movement of freight within plant premises.

“These operations were integrated with the Indian Railways (IR) network via designated interchange yards, where the IR locomotive would deliver or receive the rake and be released immediately, ensuring high asset turnover. This system has changed with the adoption of the “Engine-on-Load” policy. Now,

the same IR locomotive is required to perform the internal shunting operations within private sidings, leading to increased turnaround times with locomotives being held up inside private sidings,” he says.

He further adds Indian Railways is currently facing an acute shortage of locomotives due to a combination of reasons. “While electrification of railway routes has progressed at an unprecedented pace, the corresponding ramp-up in electric locomotive production has not kept pace. A large number of diesel locomotives—many of which still had significant residual operational life—have been prematurely grounded,” says Trivedi.

Railways has taken swift steps to meet the challenge. It has increased the target for electric locomotive

production by 10% in the current fiscal with its three major production units—Chittaranjan Locomotive Works, Patiala Locomotive Works and Banaras Locomotive Works—going all out to ramp up production. The target for electric locomotive production is 1,626 in this year (FY26) and 1,700 in FY27 compared to 1,481 and 1,272 in FY25 and FY24, respectively. In a record, the CLW, in the first quarter of FY26, has produced 200 locomotives. The budgetary allocation for the three units saw a 25% jump with ₹14,739 crore allocated in FY26 compared to ₹11,884 in FY25.

WITH A LITTLE HELP

In view of the shortage, the contribution of private players such as Siemens India and Alstom is be-